

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

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DOMINANT JUDGMENT	TEXAS AS STRATEGIC CYBER TERRAIN

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

This issue of **The Alamo Threat Brief** aligns to the week of **19 April 2026** and assesses a threat environment defined by three simultaneous shifts: **Texas is becoming strategic cyber terrain** as AI infrastructure and ERCOT load growth converge; **financial sector vendor risk is crystallizing** from a theoretical exposure into a lived, litigation-generating reality; and **DPRK insider-adjacent schemes** are moving from counterintelligence abstractions into enforced criminal sentences and active Treasury sanctions. Layered on top of all three is an Iranian OT warning environment that has not degraded since last issue, and a Russian behavioral trend in Europe that signals a deliberate escalation from nuisance operations toward disruptive effect. The central analytic judgment this week is that Texas organizations are no longer managing isolated risk vectors. They are operating inside a strategic terrain competition — where energy, AI compute, financial infrastructure, and defense industrial capacity all converge on the same geography.

Decision 1 — Grid and Infrastructure Dependency

If your organization's operations, data centers, or manufacturing are dependent on ERCOT grid reliability, decide this week whether your continuity plans reflect a future grid operating under unprecedented AI and industrial load — not the grid of the past decade. The infrastructure underneath your operations is changing faster than most continuity plans.

Decision 2 — Vendor Data Accountability

If you share customer or employee data with third-party processors, compliance platforms, or marketing vendors, decide whether you know which of those vendors could expose you to a class-action lawsuit, regulatory notice, and reputational damage without ever touching your core network. Frost and Citizens Bank answered that question the hard way.

Decision 3 — Remote Worker Identity Assurance

If your organization employs remote engineers, contractors, or technical workers, decide whether your identity verification, device validation, and payroll anomaly monitoring are strong enough to detect a DPRK-facilitated IT worker before they generate access, exfiltrate data, or trigger a sanctions compliance exposure.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

The most consequential development this week is not any single adversary action. It is the convergence of forces that are making Texas more valuable — and more vulnerable — simultaneously.

CenterPoint's disclosure of over 12 gigawatts of committed industrial load, combined with ERCOT's preliminary long-term demand projection of approximately 368,000 megawatts by 2032 against an all-time peak of roughly 85,000 megawatts in 2023, signals something qualitatively new: Texas is becoming the computational and industrial backbone of American AI, cloud, and energy infrastructure at a pace that planning cycles were not built to absorb.

That is a business and economic story. It is also a national security story. The more that AI compute, Gulf Coast petrochemicals, financial clearinghouses, health system data, and defense production concentrate on Texas infrastructure, the more attractive that infrastructure becomes to state actors seeking leverage, disruption pathways, and crisis contingency access. **Iran has already demonstrated willingness to move from reconnaissance to operational disruption** against OT environments. China continues to maintain quiet access inside U.S. critical infrastructure as a hedge for future crises. DPRK is monetizing cyber access at machine speed. Russia is signaling behavioral escalation in Europe as a model for what comes next.

Bottom line: Texas boards and executives should stop asking whether they are a target and start asking how their dependency on converging infrastructure — grid, cloud, telecom, AI compute, financial rails — changes their exposure profile as that infrastructure becomes more strategically contested.

Section I

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that Texas AI and data-center infrastructure growth is **almost certainly** transitioning from a commercial development story into a **strategic cyber terrain issue**, and that ERCOT grid reliability, Houston-area industrial load concentration, and behind-the-meter energy dependencies will become increasingly attractive targets for state-sponsored pre-positioning and disruption operations through 2026 and into 2027. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: specific adversary targeting timelines against individual facilities or operators are not yet publicly documented. The direction of travel — converging infrastructure, accelerating demand, expanding attack surface — is sufficiently established to drive defensive planning now.

KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE CONFIDENCE** that third-party vendor compromise is **likely** the most probable near-term pathway for significant cyber-related financial and reputational harm to Texas banking and financial institutions, and that **"our network was not breached" will not constitute an adequate defense** before regulators, litigants, or customers following a vendor-linked incident. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: attribution of the Frost and Citizens incidents to a specific criminal group (Everest ransomware has been cited in reporting) has not been publicly confirmed by the institutions. The structural exposure — concentrated vendor dependency — is independently verified and not uncertainty-dependent.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Legal and risk executives at Texas financial institutions should review vendor breach-notification clauses, customer data minimization posture, and incident response plan coverage for third-party scenarios.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that North Korean IT worker insertion schemes **almost certainly** represent a live insider-adjacent risk to U.S. technology, defense, AI, and financial-sector organizations, including those operating in Texas, and that DOJ sentencing and Treasury sanctions this month signal sustained enforcement attention — but not elimination of the threat. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: the full scope of DPRK-placed workers at U.S. firms is not publicly quantified. The 100+ company figure from DOJ is likely an undercount given the scale of remote technical hiring in the post-pandemic labor market.

KJ-4

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE CONFIDENCE** that Iranian cyber actors **likely** remain in a posture of active capability development and selective OT disruption, and that **Texas energy, water, and petrochemical operators using internet-exposed programmable logic controllers** remain inside the highest-risk tier even as last week's direct advisory attention recedes from headline coverage. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: the specific threshold conditions that would drive Iran to escalate OT activity against Texas targets — versus sustaining current posture — are not publicly knowable. Geopolitical tension between Iran and the United States or Israel remains the primary escalation driver to monitor.

KJ-5

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE CONFIDENCE** that pro-Russian cyber groups are **likely** deliberately escalating from denial-of-service nuisance operations toward attempted **destructive cyberattacks against critical infrastructure** in Europe, and that this behavioral escalation is a leading indicator of what Russia's cyber-adjacent ecosystem may bring to U.S. infrastructure as geopolitical friction intensifies. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: the timeline for similar escalation to manifest against U.S. targets is not established. The relevance is behavioral, not geographic: the shift from disruption-signaling to disruption-attempting is the warning indicator that matters.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas energy, water, and logistics organizations should treat the European escalation pattern as a forward-looking warning model, not a geographically distant concern.

Section II

What Changed This Week

ERCOT and Houston — AI Load Growth Reframes Grid Risk for Every Texas Sector

CenterPoint's disclosure this week of more than 12 gigawatts of firmly committed industrial load — including 3.5 gigawatts under construction and plans to serve 8 gigawatts of Greater Houston projects by 2029 — is not an incremental grid capacity story. It is a signal that the Houston region is becoming a critical node in the national AI, cloud, and industrial infrastructure ecosystem at a pace that outstrips the transmission and

generation planning cycles designed to absorb it. ERCOT's preliminary long-term demand forecast, projecting approximately 368,000 megawatts of demand by 2032 against a current all-time peak of roughly 85,500 megawatts, reinforces that the gap between current infrastructure and future load is not a minor planning variable. It is a structural risk environment that every sector operating on that grid must now account for.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Liberty CTI assesses that any Texas executive still treating ERCOT grid reliability as a background assumption — rather than an active dependency that requires scenario planning — is operating with a continuity posture that does not match the threat environment. A disruption event against grid infrastructure, telecom backbone, data-center cooling systems, or gas supply to behind-the-meter generators would not be contained to the energy sector.

Financial Sector — Frost and Citizens Show the New Shape of Bank Cyber Risk

Frost Bank is facing a proposed class-action lawsuit after a vendor-linked data breach allegedly exposed more than 100,000 customers. Citizens Bank disclosed it was managing a data extraction incident involving a third-party vendor. Both institutions reported no evidence of unauthorized access to their own core networks. That distinction — accurate as it may be — is no longer a legal or reputational shield. Customers, regulators, and plaintiff attorneys do not draw the line at the network perimeter. The exposure runs through data shared with vendors, and the liability follows the data, not the breach location.

ASSESSMENT

The Frost and Citizens incidents are the financial sector's version of a standing warning: the most likely pathway to a Texas bank's most damaging cyber incident is through a vendor it trusts, not through a perimeter it hardened.

DPRK — Laptop-Farm Sentencing Confirms Insider-Adjacent Risk Is Operational, Not Theoretical

DOJ's sentencing of two U.S. nationals who operated laptop farms enabling North Korean IT workers to pose as American employees at more than 100 U.S. companies — generating over five million dollars for Pyongyang's weapons programs — removes this threat from the abstract. Combined with Treasury's March 2026 sanctions against DPRK IT worker facilitators, this week marks the clearest enforcement signal yet that the U.S. government treats DPRK IT worker insertion as a national security issue, not a mere fraud case. The practical implication for Texas defense contractors, AI firms, fintech companies, and technology employers is direct: any remote technical hiring pipeline that lacks rigorous identity verification, device validation, and behavioral monitoring is a potential entry point for a scheme that has already successfully penetrated more than 100 American organizations.

Iran — OT Warning Environment Has Not Degraded

Reporting through this collection window continues to reflect elevated concern over Iranian cyber activity involving programmable logic controllers in U.S. critical infrastructure environments, including water and energy systems. The warning environment that produced last week's ATB lead item has not materially changed. Texas industrial operators — particularly those with internet-reachable Allen-Bradley or similar PLC environments — remain in the highest-risk tier. Geopolitical tension between Iran and the United States and Israel has not resolved in a direction that reduces this pressure.

Russia — Behavioral Escalation in Europe Is a Forward Warning for U.S. Infrastructure

Swedish government assessment reporting, corroborated by Atlantic Council analysis, describes pro-Russian groups deliberately shifting from denial-of-service activity toward attempted destructive cyberattacks against European critical infrastructure organizations. U.K. officials separately warned that serious cyber threats to European infrastructure are increasingly emanating from Russia, Iran, and China. The shift from nuisance operations to disruption-attempting behavior is the analytically significant change. Russia's cyber ecosystem — both state and state-tolerated criminal actors — is testing whether European targets can be made to feel operational pain, not just inconvenience. That behavioral evolution is a leading indicator for what may follow against U.S. infrastructure as the war in Ukraine and associated geopolitical friction continue.

Section III

Geopolitical Drivers & Texas Cyber Implications

AI Infrastructure Competition — Texas Is Becoming a Node in a Strategic Contest

What Happened: The United States and China are competing across AI infrastructure, semiconductor supply chains, cloud dominance, and computational capacity. Texas is emerging as one of the most consequential geography-specific expressions of that competition because of its energy base, land availability, pro-development regulatory posture, and hyperscale data-center footprint.

Why It Matters: Infrastructure that is strategically valuable to U.S. economic competitiveness is also strategically valuable to adversaries seeking pre-positioning access, disruption leverage, or intelligence collection. The ERCOT grid, Greater Houston energy infrastructure, data-center cooling and power dependencies, and telecom backbone supporting AI compute are not just commercial assets. They are becoming national security terrain.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): CEOs and boards whose operations depend on grid reliability, cloud continuity, or data-center availability should treat the ERCOT load growth story not as background context but as a dependency mapping imperative. When a grid or cloud disruption happens in this environment, it will not be contained.

ASSESSMENT

The more Texas becomes the backbone of American AI infrastructure, the more it becomes a priority target for adversaries seeking leverage over U.S. economic and military capacity.

North Korea — Sanctions Pressure Is Sustaining, Not Reducing, Cyber Theft Tempo

What Happened: DOJ enforcement actions and Treasury sanctions this month reinforce that DPRK uses cyber operations as a primary mechanism for sanctions evasion and WMD program finance. Enforcement signals from U.S. agencies are intensifying — but so is DPRK's operational tempo and sophistication.

Why It Matters: North Korea does not have the option to stop. Sanctions create the pressure that makes cyber theft essential. As long as maximum-pressure sanctions remain in place and Pyongyang's weapons programs require hard-currency revenue, DPRK cyber actors will continue to pursue financial theft, IT worker insertion, and data exfiltration at scale.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Texas technology employers, defense contractors, AI development firms, and fintech companies are all operating in hiring environments where DPRK actors have already demonstrated the ability to insert fraudulent workers. The risk is not geographic — it is sectoral. Any

organization in those categories is a potential target.

ASSESSMENT

DPRK enforcement actions did not eliminate the threat. They confirmed how deeply embedded the scheme already was, and signaled that U.S. organizations have been systematically targeted at a scale most have not yet internalized.

Iran — Asymmetric Coercion Remains Cyber-Enabled

What Happened: Iran-U.S. tensions remain elevated across multiple vectors, including proxy activity, nuclear posture, and regional competition. Iran continues to treat cyber as an asymmetric tool that can impose cost and signal resolve below the threshold of conventional military response.

Why It Matters: Iran's willingness to generate confirmed OT disruption — demonstrated through prior exploitation of Rockwell Automation PLC environments — signals that Tehran has crossed the threshold from reconnaissance to operational effect. The question is not whether Iran can disrupt Texas industrial environments. It is what geopolitical conditions would drive that decision.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Texas operators of energy, water, petrochemical, and industrial infrastructure who have not yet hardened PLC access, segmented OT environments, or validated manual fallback procedures are operating with known, unaddressed risk. That is now a board-level accountability question, not a technology team backlog item.

ASSESSMENT

Iran is the actor most likely to convert geopolitical escalation into confirmed operational disruption against Texas industrial systems in the near term.

Russia — War-Driven Escalation Is Changing the Behavioral Baseline

What Happened: Russia's protracted war in Ukraine continues to generate spillover pressure against Western institutions through both state and state-tolerated criminal actors. The behavioral shift now being documented in European infrastructure — from signaling disruption to attempting disruption — is not a peripheral development. It is a data point about how Russia's threshold for acceptable cyber aggression is moving.

Why It Matters: Texas organizations in energy, logistics, manufacturing, and finance are exposed to a mature Russia-based criminal ecosystem that can scale through supply chain compromise, credential theft, and identity abuse. If Russia's behavioral baseline is shifting toward destructive intent in Europe, U.S. critical infrastructure organizations should treat that as advance warning, not distant noise.

ASSESSMENT

Russia does not need to specifically target Texas to create Texas-level damage. The escalation model being tested in Europe is the warning indicator to watch.

Section IV

Sector Watchpoints — Texas Focus

Energy ERCOT / OT / Grid	What changed: CenterPoint's committed load disclosures and ERCOT's preliminary long-term demand forecast project a grid operating at conditions far beyond historical precedent within six years. Iranian OT warning environment remains elevated without material degradation from last week. Why it matters locally: Houston-area industrial and data-center load is concentrating at a pace that creates single-region grid dependencies. A cyber event targeting substation control systems, gas supply to behind-the-meter generators, or cooling infrastructure at data centers during high-demand periods would not be a bounded outage — it would cascade across sectors. Cross-sector risk: Hospitals on generator backup, payment rails dependent on data-center uptime, defense production lines requiring uninterrupted power, and AI compute infrastructure supporting national security workloads all share the same underlying grid dependency.
Financial Banking / Fintech / Payments	What changed: Frost Bank proposed class-action and Citizens Bank disclosure confirm that third-party vendor compromise is a live, litigation-generating exposure for Texas financial institutions. DPRK IT worker sentencing reinforces that financial-sector employers face an insider-adjacent risk through remote technical hiring. Why it matters locally: Frost is a major regional institution with concentrated Texas customer trust. A sustained fraud, litigation, and regulatory cycle damages not only Frost but regional confidence in the financial sector's ability to manage data shared with third parties. Cross-sector risk: Financial-sector disruption cascades to payroll processing, vendor payment timelines, healthcare billing, and energy commodity trading — all of which operate on financial rails that are no more resilient than the vendors serving them.
Healthcare Hospitals / Health Systems / Data	What changed: No new Texas-specific healthcare incident this week, but the vendor concentration pattern driving financial-sector exposure is structurally identical to healthcare's third-party risk profile. AI-enabled autonomous cyber tools, flagged this week as a strategic trend, are being tested against healthcare environments. Why it matters locally: Texas Medical Center is the world's largest medical complex. A vendor-enabled disruption affecting health system billing, records access, or clinical device management during a period of AI-driven adversary tempo increase would compress response time for hospital leadership in ways that traditional incident response planning does not account for. Cross-sector risk: Hospital systems dependent on ERCOT reliability, cloud-hosted EHR platforms, and third-party billing processors face compounded exposure when multiple dependencies are simultaneously stressed.

Defense / DIB Contractors / AI / Data Centers	What changed: DPRK IT worker sentencing directly implicates the DIB. DOJ's documented penetration of more than 100 U.S. companies — including technology and defense-adjacent employers — means the risk of an existing DPRK-placed worker inside a San Antonio-area or Texas-based defense contractor is not hypothetical. Treasury sanctions reinforce that this is a sanctions-compliance issue, not only a cybersecurity one. Why it matters locally: San Antonio's cyber and defense ecosystem — JBSA, NSA Texas, defense contractors, and adjacent technology firms — is one of the densest in the country. DPRK's targeting logic follows workforce access, engineering roles, and sensitive program adjacency. Cross-sector risk: A DPRK IT worker with access to defense production systems or sensitive program data creates a counterintelligence failure that can take months or years to fully scope, even after detection.
AI / Data Centers Compute / Cloud / Infrastructure	What changed: Foreign Affairs and New York Times analysis, summarized this week, assesses that autonomous AI agents may soon be capable of conducting cyber campaigns at nation-state scale — compressing what previously required expert human labor into automated, persistent, high-volume operations. Combined with Texas's rapidly expanding AI compute footprint, this trend has direct local relevance within the 12–24 month planning horizon. Why it matters locally: Texas data centers are not just commercial infrastructure. They are housing workloads that touch defense, financial clearing, healthcare records, and AI training pipelines for national security applications. A successful intrusion into shared cloud or data-center infrastructure could create lateral exposure across multiple sector dependencies simultaneously. Cross-sector risk: AI infrastructure disruption or compromise ripples immediately into energy (compute demand), finance (algorithmic and payment systems), healthcare (AI-assisted diagnostics and records), and DIB (classified-adjacent AI workloads).

Section V

Priority Intelligence Requirements — Weekly Update

PIR 1 Foreign cyber pre-positioning in Texas energy infrastructure [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch PUCT large-load approval timelines and grid equipment supply-chain disclosures
- Watch ERCOT emergency declarations and behind-the-meter generator fuel contract anomalies
- Watch for CISA advisories specific to Texas utility vendors or substation control suppliers

ERCOT demand projections and CenterPoint load disclosures confirm Texas energy infrastructure is growing in strategic value at a rate that outpaces defensive adaptation. Iranian OT warning environment remains elevated. PRC pre-positioning doctrine — quiet access, long dwell — has not changed. This PIR remains the highest-priority collection focus for Liberty CTI in 2026.

PIR 6 Financial sector software supply chain and vendor cyber risk [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch Texas Attorney General breach notification filings for additional financial-sector vendors
- Watch Everest ransomware leak-site activity for Frost or Citizens-linked data publication
- Watch for other Texas financial institutions served by the same vendor infrastructure

Frost and Citizens incidents move this PIR from theoretical to confirmed this week. Third-party data exposure is generating class-action litigation, regulatory attention, and customer harm without direct network

compromise. This is the active mechanism — not a hypothetical pathway.

PIR 12 Insider threat and workforce risk to defense and critical infrastructure [â†‘ Rising]

- Watch DOJ indictments and civil enforcement actions related to DPRK IT worker facilitation
- Watch Treasury OFAC designations of DPRK-linked entities active in technology labor markets
- Watch for Texas-based employer disclosures tied to DPRK worker investigations

DPRK laptop-farm sentencing elevates this PIR from watch to active monitoring. The documented scale — 100+ U.S. companies — and the enforcement signal from both DOJ and Treasury indicate sustained DPRK investment in this vector. Texas defense, AI, and fintech employers are directly in scope.

Section VI

Executive Warning Indicators

These are the observable signals that would indicate a meaningful shift in Texas cyber risk posture. Leadership should monitor these over the coming week and treat any confirmed trigger as a decision-forcing event.

W-1 ERCOT emergency operations center activation or PUCT large-load rule suspension — indicates the grid is operating outside normal parameters during a high-demand period; triggers continuity plan review for any organization dependent on uninterrupted power.

W-2 Additional Texas financial institutions disclosing vendor-linked breach notifications — indicates the Frost/Citizens vendor event is a shared-vendor exposure, not two isolated incidents; triggers immediate vendor audit for any Texas bank using the same compliance, data, or payments infrastructure.

W-3 CISA advisory or joint federal warning specific to Texas utility vendor or data-center operator — indicates state-sponsored actors have moved from general U.S. targeting to Texas-specific infrastructure activity; highest-urgency trigger for energy and AI infrastructure operators.

W-4 DOJ indictment or Treasury sanction of entity linked to Texas employer in DPRK IT worker investigation — indicates a Texas-based organization has already been penetrated; triggers immediate workforce identity audit and counsel engagement for defense, AI, and fintech employers.

W-5 Iran-linked destructive cyberattack against a U.S. energy or water facility that produces confirmed operational outage — indicates Iranian threshold for escalation has lowered; triggers immediate OT isolation review for any Texas industrial operator.

W-6 Confirmed destructive cyberattack by pro-Russian group against a NATO member's critical infrastructure — indicates the European escalation model has produced an operational success; triggers review of Texas energy and logistics organizations' exposure to Russia-aligned criminal ecosystem.

W-7 Major Texas data-center operator disclosing unplanned outage with unknown cause — indicates possible cyber action against compute infrastructure; triggers cross-sector dependency assessment for any organization relying on that operator's cloud or colocation services.

W-8 DPRK cryptocurrency theft targeting a Texas-based financial institution or fintech platform — confirms DPRK has expanded from crypto-native targets to Texas financial infrastructure; triggers immediate crypto integration audit and DeFi partnership review.

Section VII

Executive Implications & Recommended Actions

1 — Map Your Grid and Infrastructure Dependencies

Identify which operations would fail first — and within what timeframe — if ERCOT experienced a major disruption event. Include generator fuel contracts, cloud failover, telecommunications backup, and any water or cooling dependencies tied to facility operations. **What happens if you get this wrong:** you discover your actual continuity posture in the middle of an incident rather than before one.

2 — Audit Third-Party Data Access Before a Regulator Does

Identify every vendor with access to customer, employee, or sensitive business data. For each, confirm breach notification contract language, subcontractor visibility, data minimization posture, and incident response SLAs.

What happens if you get this wrong: you face the same class-action exposure that Frost and Citizens are managing, with less preparation time and more press attention.

3 — Harden Remote Worker Verification for Technical Roles

Implement live video verification at hire, physical device delivery confirmation, payroll routing anomaly monitoring, geolocation consistency checks for remote access, and regular re-verification for sensitive engineering roles.

What happens if you get this wrong: you create a sanctions compliance exposure, a counterintelligence failure, and an insider access risk that may already exist inside your organization.

4 — Validate OT Segmentation and PLC Access Pathways

For any Texas operator with internet-connected industrial control systems, validate remote access pathways, confirm segmentation between IT and OT environments, review default credential status, and confirm manual fallback procedures. **What happens if you get this wrong:** Iran or a criminal proxy turns an unaddressed OT exposure into an operational outage with safety implications.

5 — Brief Your Board on the Strategic Terrain Shift

The convergence of AI infrastructure, ERCOT load growth, financial vendor concentration, and multi-actor threat pressure is a board-level governance issue. If your board's understanding of cyber risk is still organized around perimeter defense and compliance frameworks, it is not calibrated for the threat environment Texas organizations are now operating in. **What happens if you get this wrong:** your board approves a risk posture that does not reflect reality, leaving executives without institutional support when an incident forces escalation.

Section VIII

Analyst's Note

ANALYST'S NOTE

The defining analytical challenge this week is not identifying new adversaries or new tactics. It is helping Texas executives understand that the ground beneath their organizations is shifting in a way that makes familiar risk assumptions obsolete. Most continuity plans in Texas were built against a grid that peaked at 85,000 megawatts and a cyber threat environment defined by ransomware and phishing. Neither of those baselines describes what executives are operating in today.

ERCOT is being asked to absorb demand projections that are an order of magnitude beyond its all-time peak within six years. Vendors that Texas financial institutions trusted with customer data are being exploited without touching the banks' own networks. DPRK has already successfully placed workers inside more than 100 U.S. companies, and enforcement this month confirmed that those operations generated millions of dollars for weapons programs while extracting access from organizations that never knew they were compromised. Iran has demonstrated willingness to disrupt industrial control systems. Russia's proxies are practicing destructive attacks against European infrastructure in what reads analytically as rehearsal behavior.

The practical question for leadership is not whether any of these represent a plausible threat to Texas. The question is whether your current planning — your board briefings, your vendor contracts, your continuity scenarios, your workforce verification controls — reflects an environment where all five of these pressures are operating simultaneously, and where the infrastructure your organization depends on is becoming more strategically contested every quarter. **If the honest answer is no, that gap is the decision requiring action this week.**

Section IX — Sourcing

Source Notes**OPEN SOURCE BASIS — ATB-2026-7 — WEEK OF 19 APRIL 2026****ERCOT and CenterPoint load-growth reporting**

[ERCOT forecast](#)

Frost Bank and Citizens Bank breach reporting

[PYMNTS report](#)

U.S. Department of Justice DPRK laptop-farm sentencing

[DOJ release](#)

U.S. Treasury OFAC DPRK IT-worker sanctions

[Treasury release](#)

Iranian PLC exploitation and warning environment

[EPA advisory release](#)

Russia-linked destructive cyber activity in Europe

[Atlantic Council dispatch](#)

AI-enabled autonomous cyber intrusion analysis

[LevelBlue analysis](#)

Liberty CTI standing analytical baseline

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: Texas is experiencing simultaneous pressure from AI infrastructure load growth creating new strategic cyber terrain on the ERCOT grid; vendor-enabled data exposure generating litigation and regulatory risk for Texas financial institutions; DPRK IT worker insertion confirmed at scale across U.S. employers; an undiminished Iranian OT warning environment; and documented Russian escalation toward destructive cyber effects in Europe. **WHO:** PRC Typhoon clusters (pre-positioning), IRGC-linked OT actors (disruptive intent), Lazarus and DPRK IT worker networks (financial theft and insider access), pro-Russian criminal groups (escalating disruption), and ransomware ecosystems exploiting vendor trust relationships. **WHY:** AI infrastructure competition, geopolitical coercion, sanctions evasion, WMD program finance, and financially motivated criminal disruption are all converging on the same Texas infrastructure base. **WHAT NEXT:** Texas organizations should expect the strategic terrain competition to intensify as ERCOT load commitments grow, should treat vendor accountability as an immediate legal and operational priority, and should implement remote workforce verification controls before enforcement or counterintelligence action forces the issue.

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